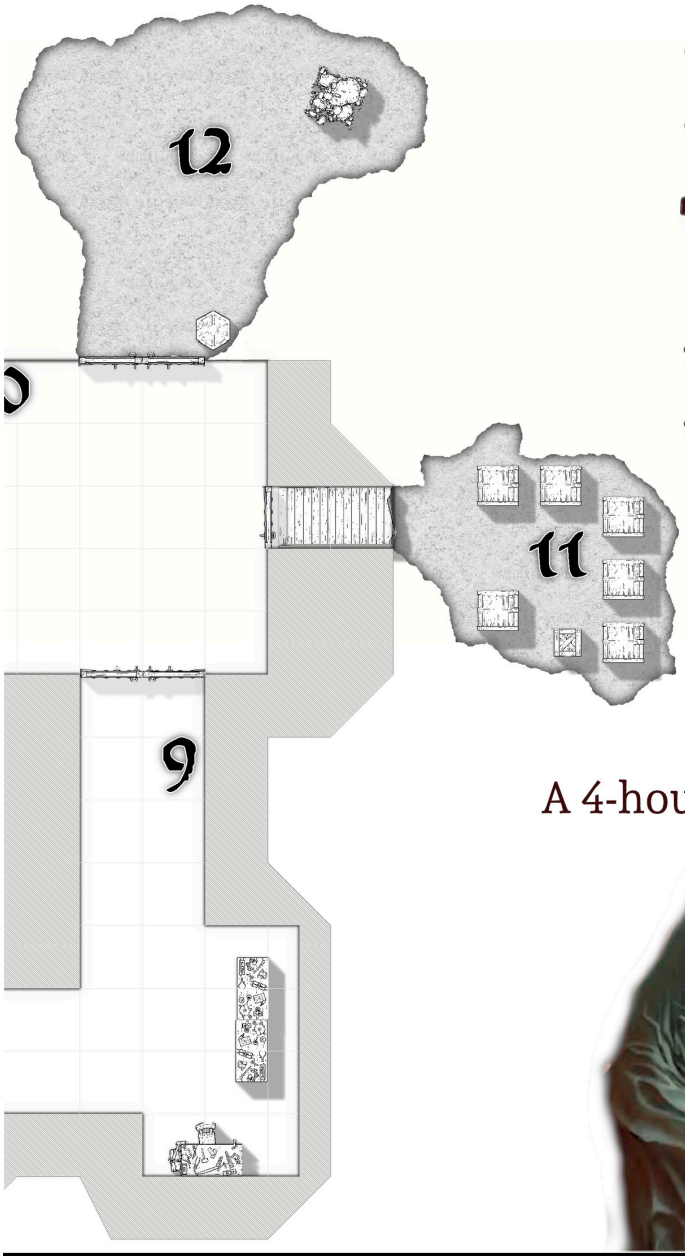


Beware The Moonless Night

A 4-hour Adventure for Level 1-4 Characters



By M. Paul Butcher

BEWARE THE MOONLESS NIGHT

A Mystery

Introduction: Seven children have been snatched from their homes as they slept. The adventurers must stop the perpetrators before another child falls victim. Not all is as it seems when the adventurers discover the true nature of the hill at the center of the town.

A 4-hour adventure for 1st-4th level characters

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Beware the Moonless Night

"It is foolish to confuse gaining wealth with achieving greatness."

— Thalia Bloodwight, Journal 7

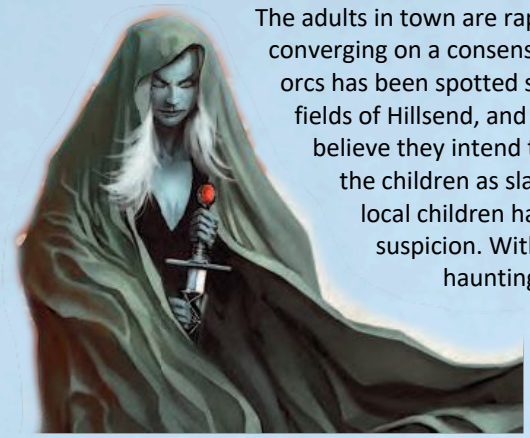
Introduction

This is a 4-6 hour encounter designed for tier 1 players. It is optimized for five level 3 players The three-part format involves an investigation, an orc hunt, and a dungeon crawl. The adventure is setting-neutral but refers to deities common in the Forgotten Realms. Places and names can be adapted to fit into your desired setting.

The Adventure Summary

The goal of this adventure is to solve the mystery of the vanishing children, rescue them, and recover the formula for a valuable artifact.

In the last few weeks, seven children have vanished from the ranching village of Hillsend. Townsfolk are reacting with a mix of anger, fear, and willful denial. The adults in town are rapidly converging on a consensus: A band of orcs has been spotted skirting the fields of Hillsend, and the townsfolk believe they intend to use or sell the children as slaves. But the local children have a darker suspicion. With an oni haunting their dreams, the children are repeating a chilling rhyme.



Groth (LE female oni) has insinuated herself into the town's trust by impersonating a local messenger named Delbert Dingleham (CN male human commoner). Disguised, Groth selects her targets by day, returning to kidnap them at night. As the truth surfaces, the adventurers discover that this quaint little town was built on the burial site of an ancient king intent on acquiring the power of Gehenna. His tomb holds what may be the last surviving copy of the formula for constructing a Brimstone Mace. Almgrasp (LE male duergar), a treasure-seeking dwarf, has left his home in the underdark in search of the king's vile treasure. And with the help of the oni and several enslaved children, he expects to dig his way into the mound, which hides a labyrinthine underground tomb.

Fighting their way through the denizens of the tomb, the party is faced with one final choice: Destroy the formula in the eternal flames of the shrine in the tomb or keep it that they one day may build the cursed weapon.

The Setting and Background

It is midsummer in Hillsend. Normally, the farmers' greatest concern would be keeping the jackals away from their herds. But troublesome events have dominated the last few weeks.

Hillsend is a meager rural community populated largely by animal farmers. Raising a variety of stock, from cattle to giant goats, the ranchers make a living selling to the butchers of nearby cities. It is not uncommon to see a farmer loading livestock onto a wagon to be carted several days' journey down the Eiderwend.

The fields surrounding the town have been parceled out by the farmers, who graze their herds on the clover-filled prairie. While the landscape is predominantly low rolling field, one tall round hill, bare of vegetation, stands tall. The town of Hillsend is nestled at the foot of the hill. The locals are unaware that this hill is not natural. It is all that remains of a dwarf fortress and mine that was intentionally collapsed more than a thousand years ago.

In dwarven lore, King Sherstave Torbrand is a minor but tragic figure. Having relocated a cohort of dwarves from a failing mine to the east, Torbrand convinced his people that vast wealth lay hidden beneath the prairie. He envisioned building a fortress-mine that could at once produce wealth and act as a palace. Torbrand's true reason for selecting that location, though, was to find a fabled passage to Gehenna, where he sought to acquire a sample of

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brimstone. The brimstone was a necessary ingredient for a powerful and malevolent weapon: The Brimstone Mace. Torbrand sought not only wealth but unrivaled power.

His plan never came to fruition. In the mine, he located neither precious metals nor the portal. When a marauding orc horde laid siege to the mine, Torbrand died in battle as the dwarven enclave was decimated. Barely fighting back the orcs, the remaining dwarves buried their dead and returned to their old home. With another orc attack looming, the dwarves collapsed the entrance and mounded it with dirt and rock. Sherstave Torbrand's fortress-mine became the unmarked tomb of a failed king.

Hundreds of years later, human settlers saw the land as a source of a different kind of wealth: The vast expanse of green prairie was a perfect spot for raising livestock. So a village sprung forth in front of the mound of Sherstave Torbrand. Generation after generation, the small community eked out a space in the area economy.

The town itself is small, consisting of fewer than two dozen buildings. At the town center is a tethering pole, around which the town mercantile, tavern, and blacksmith are arranged. Unaccustomed to travelers, the tavern has only two rooms. Ranchers in the area, though, are known to put up travelers in their barns, and perhaps even feed them, for a paltry fee of 2 sp a day.

The mercantile is oriented around the needs of the locals, with food stuffs, animal feed, and farming supplies as the staples. The blacksmith's shop is active from sunrise to sunset as all manner of horseshoes, harnesses, tools, and utensils are produced by the blacksmith and her apprentice. So important is the blacksmith’s role that the shop is as much a social hub as a workspace. Just off the town center is the town hall, which is a single-story building of rough stone. Inside, the layout is similar to a cottage, except what would be the bedroom is a simple jail cell (unoccupied), and the townmaster's desk sits before the fireplace.



Life in Hillsend is anything but idyllic. Wolves, jackals and other predators hunt the herds of domesticated animals. For protection, the locals employ elaborate measures including traps, enchantments, and equally menacing beasts trained to defend the livestock. Furthermore, cattle herding in these hills is competitive. Accusations of grazing herds in another person's field have been known to boil over into egregious acts of violence. Feuds last decades or even generations as ranchers connive to expand their herds, their territory, and their purses at the expense of their fellow townsfolk. The most successful herder, Rance Spinner, pulls the political strings in the town. With the townmaster under his thumb, Rance regularly deploys his thugs to ensure that he gets his way. Utterly unsympathetic to the plight of other townsfolk, Rance schemes to snatch a significant portion of Terrence and Trudy Ulbert's land.

The Adventure Hook

It is a brisk morning as the party walks along the Eiderwend Road. After spending the better part of the day walking across the low ridges of a prairie, the town in the distance is a welcome change of scenery.

The small countryside hamlet sits among large fields of yellow clover, the grazing grounds for all variety of beast raised by the local herders. Split rail fences parcel the fields into individual farms. Here and there, small retention ponds surrounded by trees dot the landscape, serving as water sources for the animals and swimming holes for the local children.

As the party approaches the town, a woman (Trudy Ulbert, LG female human commoner) rushes onto the road. Running toward the adventurers, she is sobbing hysterically as she begs the adventurers to help her. Read or paraphrase:

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> "My daughter," she cries, "Gert! She's vanished! Snatched from her bed in the night! This has happened too many times. Too many children are lost. Please, I beg you… do something!"

Before she can provide further information, a pair of villagers (Rance Spinner's thugs, LE humanoid thug) catch up to her and grab her shoulders. Roughly pulling her back, they drag her off toward the town. Apologizing to the party, they claim that she's overreacting, that she's lost her mind, and that everything is alright. They suggest that the adventurers continue on their journey.

If the party follows, the thugs bring her back to the town hall, drag her through the door, and then bar the door from the inside. From inside, the voices urge the adventurers to continue on their way.

Regardless of whether the party follows her, when she vanishes from sight, another townsperson, Winthroop Millerson (LG male half-orc commoner) catches the party's attention and motions them over. In his slow deliberate speech colored by rural drawl, Winthroop tells the party that something suspicious is going on.

Counting Gert, seven children have vanished over the last few weeks. Each taken from home during the night, the children simply disappear. No screams, no blood… just open windows and empty beds. Winthroop informs the party that the people around town are divided over what should be done. The families that have lost children are understandably keen to act. But others, particularly the Townmaster Chickpea and rancher Rance Spinner, have been downplaying the events, suggesting it is a hoax. Winthroop is not sure why those in power have been so reluctant to act.

Winthrop tells the party that while the town is generally suspicious of foreigners, he thinks it's time they get help. He begs the adventurers to help solve the mystery. He suggests that he will get together with the parents of missing children and raise enough money to pay the adventurers should they solve the riddle.

Winthroop suggests that the adventurers talk to Terrence Ulbert, letting him know that his wife is being held at the town hall. He will provide directions to Ulbert Farm. If prompted for more leads, he will point the party toward other parents, the townmaster, and the blacksmith. Winthroop is the owner of the mercantile and returns to work after talking to the party.

Additional Enticement

If the party needs additional enticement, you may work in an external rumor from far away that this town is home to a hidden mine hiding an ancient dwarven treasure. However, make sure that when framing this out it does not suggest that any of the townspeople know this.

The Investigation

In this phase of the adventure, the party should focus on investigating the disappearances. The Ulberts, whom the characters already know, are likely the first. In that encounter, the Ulberts need to mention enough other leads that the party has at least a few follow-up options. Players may ask the right questions ("Do you know the other parents?", or "Can you think of anyone who might have done this?"). But if not, you can work the leads into the Ulberts' dialog ("Here's a list of the other parents…").

The Ulberts

Terrence and Trudy Ulbert have lost their daughter Gert, who vanished from her bed in the night (a common theme among all the missing children). Terrence is a hard-working farmer who is honest, unsentimental, and blunt. Trudy is also hard working but is less direct than her husband. She chooses her words carefully, and many a time this skill has extracted Terrence from a difficult situation.

Along with Gert, the Ulberts have a second (younger) child. Hadley (LG male human commoner) is eight years old. Short for his age, he was also born mute. For this reason, the other children in town call him Hardly ("he's HARDLY good for anything"). Without Gert, his defender and companion, Hadley is morose and reclusive. Ignored by others, he has been spending his solitary days searching for his sister. To communicate, Hadley uses hand gestures or writes simple notes.

Trudy is released from the town master's hall as soon as the adventurers are out of sight. She will head back home. If the party goes directly from their

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meeting with Winthroop, they may arrive at the farm a few minutes before Trudy. Terrence will be there, though.

As with all of the homes in Hillsend, the Ulbert house is a modest farmhouse with a stone foundation, wood structure, and thatched roof. Behind the house is a small garden and a chicken coop, along with the customary farm tools. A few hundred feet away is the barn, a narrow home for the Ulberts' work animals.

When the party visits the Ulberts, they can learn the following things from Terrence and Trudy.

- Terrence and neighbor Rance Spinner have a long-standing feud. In Terrence's telling, Rance is attempting to slowly take the Ulbert property, moving fences, feeding his herds on Terrence's property, and making spurious legal claims to the townmaster.
- As with many of the locals, Terrence and Trudy have lost more than the usual number of animals. The Ulberts raise giant goats. Recently, they lost four in a day and haven't found so much as a carcass.
- Gert had no particular enemies, no reason to wander off, and was not a particularly adventurous child. The Ulberts strongly believe that Gert's disappearance (as well as the others) was a kidnapping. Terrence expresses disgust at the Townmaster's reluctance to do anything. Trudy, usually the more reserved of the two, is furious.
- Terrence suspects that Rance, who has vocally resisted doing something about the disappearances, is involved in the kidnappings.

They have heard only second hand rumors of orcs and have no other theories as to what happened to Gert.

If an adventurer tries to talk to Hadley, he will shy away, but will also smile. If his parents are present, they will explain his inability to speak.

The Other Parents

Seven children are missing in total. While there is no need for the party to interview each and every parent, this section provides information that you may use either for interviews or for background material.

The following parents or grandparents have also lost children:

Jeen Fensley (N female human): Her daughter Lilla (N female human) was the first to be taken, just over two weeks ago. Lilla is an accomplished rider, and popular in town.

Flint (N male human) and Maggie (LG female half-elf) Wetshaw: Their son Garett was the second child taken 12 days ago. Garett is a rowdy child and had a reputation for challenging other children to contests of strength. Flint brags that Garett once lifted a giant goat off the ground several inches before the goat delivered a bruising kick to Garett's shin. He believes that only a band of orcs are strong enough to have captured his son.

Bensley and Naomi Kant (NG human): They lost their grandson Peel (N male half-elf) 10 days ago. Peel's parents had perished in a fire seven years ago, and Bensley and Naomi have been raising him ever since. While hard working, Peel is painfully shy. He is friends with Lilla Fensley, and when she disappeared, he took it hard. His grandparents are concerned that he may have intentionally left to find Lilla. The Kants blame Rance Spinner, whom they refer to as "that nasty conniving con artist."

Danert Woostley (NG male human): His daughter Sadie (N female human) is his pride and joy. She vanished nine days ago. Danert is worried that Sadie's vegetable garden will wilt without her care. He gets choked up as he relays how his wife also loved gardening before she died of fever. Danert claims to have seen a band of orcs roaming around the border of his field four days ago, and he is convinced that orcs are responsible for the disappearances.

Stockton (LG male human) and Jule (NG female human) Harl: The Harl's daughter Keen vanished the same night as Sadie. Keen and Sadie were close friends but had not seen each other that day. Keen is the third child of five, and her brothers and sisters are shaken and scared. The Stocktons run The Sheered Goat, the local tavern and inn. They relay stories of orcs told by travelers that have stopped at the inn.

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Stalward Hammersmelt (LG male dwarf): His son Bristle (CN male dwarf) was the second-to-last victim. It had been seven days since Keen disappeared. The town was silently relieved that, though unresolved, the disappearances seemed to have stopped. And then Bristle's bed was found empty, window ajar. Bristle is the eldest of the disappeared, at 15. He is also likely the strongest (though the Wetshaws may disagree). Hammersmelt suggests that "something deep isn't right with this town," but cannot elaborate other than saying he just feels it and has always felt it. "Something is just not right with the earth here," he says, drawing on his dwarven heritage.

The Wetshaws, the Kants, and Danert Woostley each live a few miles outside of town on the land close to their flocks. The rest live in town. The farmhouses are similar to the Ulberts', while homes in or near town are cottages, typically made of stone and lumber with thatched or slate roofs. Homes in town may have small gardens, but do not tend to have medium or larger livestock.

In addition to the specifics above, each family reports the same general pattern: The children showed no abnormal behavior before the disappearance (though one or two might mention bad dreams). All disappeared from bed in the night, and in all cases a window was left ajar or even removed from its frame. While some parents are more emotive than others, each one entreats the adventurers to bring their children safely home.

Characters may point the party toward Chap Fernsley ("in a town like this, the blacksmith knows everybody and hears everything") as well as Townmaster Chickpea. Someone might suggest asking Delbert the messenger but warns that he's too aloof to be of much use in a serious inquiry. More than one suggests interviewing Rance Spinner, but with firm insistence that Rance is not trustworthy. If the party hasn't visited the Ulberts yet, characters will suggest them as well.

In spite of the frequent mention of orcs, none of the villagers know where the orcs currently are. (The orcs appear in part 2, A Change of Heart.)

The Blacksmith

Chap Fernsley (NG female half-orc) is an honest woman who takes pride in her smith work. She knows everyone in town, as all come to her for her services. Social and talkative, she considers herself a collector and distributor of local information.

The blacksmith shop is open air. A large bellows and furnace stand in the center surrounded by tools. Chap's apprentice is continually toiling away at the anvil or the bellows while Chap herself does more detailed work and chats with bystanders. Small groups tend to gather near the shop to share the latest news and gossip. With the noise of the shop, even confidential information is shouted so that it may be heard over the clanging.

Chap can direct the party to the parents and guardians of the missing children, as well as fill in backstory. She might, for example, suggest interviewing certain people while merely summarizing the situation of others. (You can use this as a device for keeping the party from spending hours interviewing each family at length.)

She will also mention that among the daily woes of the herders is the disappearance of animals. "It's normal for a herd to lose a straggler to the wolves or jackals, but there are a few folks who claim to be losing five or more at a time." While predators tend to leave the carcasses after feasting, this time around the animal bodies don't seem to show up. (It is later revealed that the animals are taken by a band of orcs.)

The Townmaster

Marcus Chickpea (N male human) is the townmaster. Indecisive and ineloquent, he performs his duties with minimal effort, relying on Rance Spinner and his thugs to "carry out justice." When confronted with complexities or tragedies, Chickpea dithers, refusing to confront the situation head on.

The town hall has only two rooms: A main room in which Chickpea does his daily work, and a small room with barred door that serves sometimes as storage space and other times as a jail. At the moment, it is unoccupied.

Inept though he may be, Chickpea is genuinely concerned with the disappearance of the local children. On most matters, he will defend Rance. But he cannot understand why Rance (who is uninterested in the disappearances) won't do anything about the children. At the same time,

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though, Chickpea will not stand up to Rance or take initiative on his own.

He has no real theories. He may in one breath opine that children are mischievous and enjoy playing pranks, while in another suggest that he has heard about towns where the children were taken and sold into slavery. He seems unbothered by his self-contradictions.

If asked about why the thugs dragged Trudy Ulbert into the town hall, Chickpea will talk about how the town in general, and Rance in particular, is cautious about the interference of outsiders. With herding as a way of life, folk tend to be suspicious that outsiders are there to try to claim land or take animals. Chickpea suggests that the way to appease Rance is to appeal to his financial interests.

Chickpea has heard rumors of a band of orcs harassing travelers and poaching animals. He hasn't personally seen any. Townsfolk have reported their lost livestock, and while some have blamed the orcs, others have blamed their neighbors or other area farmers, and still others suspect a pack of hyenas or wolves.

Like Chap, Chickpea can direct the adventurers toward the parents of the children, as well as summarize their situations. Officially having the role of justice of the peace, Chickpea has talked to the parents and guardians for every lost child.

The Bigshot

Rance Spinner (CE male human commoner) acts as though he runs the town. And with good reason. With Marcus in his pocket, Rance's word is quite often made law. Rance's **thugs** (MM 350) have been deputized by Townmaster Chickpea and frequently use their authority in blatantly unjust ways.

Preferring to leave the business of herding to his underlings, Rance can be found in one of three places: the town hall, his own farmhouse south of the Ulberts' and east of town, or near the blacksmith's shop. Rance and Chap do not necessarily see eye-to-eye, but both value the exchange of information. Therefore, they tolerate each other.

The Spinner farm is the town's largest, nearly double the size of the Ulberts'. Unlike the small neighboring farmhouses, the Spinner house is sprawling, built entirely of stone with new slate roofing. It has several outbuildings, including an enormous barn as well as a lodge house for his hired thugs. The Spinner farm has stood generations, but not until Rance's father took over did it enjoy such prosperity. Rance has inherited his father's ambition and has few scruples about expanding at the cost of his neighbors.

Rance views the party as nosy foreigners who nevertheless might be bent to his purposes. He is cordial and generous, offering to put them up in his barn "for free." But he expects them to assist him in his campaign against the Ulberts. For example, he suggests that they tear down a two-mile section of "old and decomposing" fence that borders the Ulberts' land so that he can later rebuild that section of fencing. He points out that the fence was built in the wrong place to begin with, and this is an opportunity to set the boundaries right.

Regarding the disappearance of the town's children, Rance has little to say. While he doesn't express it directly, he does not care about the disappearances because they have no direct impact on his own interests. He has two theories, though he holds neither with conviction: He's heard rumors of orcs, and orcs are always bad for business. Or perhaps the children are all camped out somewhere, having a good laugh at their parents' overreactions.

Rance has a child, eleven-year-old Steel, but he doesn't talk about family unless directly asked. He thinks about business first, and family only as an afterthought.

While Rance is underhanded and conniving, he presents no actual threat. His thirst for power extends no further than the local fields and livestock. Likewise, his men might act brutish, but at their core they are merely hired muscle.

The Mute Child

While the party may first encounter Hadley Ulbert at the family home, Hadley doesn't stay there. Driven by love for his sister Gert, and enamored with the adventurers, he does his own investigation. Hadley follows the party frequently. He is small and quiet and can only be seen with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check. If seen, he will either wave shyly and walk away, or attempt to run and

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hide. If the party catches him, he will do his best to convey that he cannot speak.

Eventually, Hadley will work up the courage to deliver a note to the person in the party whom he admires the most. The note has a nursery rhyme on it:

> Beware, my child, the moonless night,
> A creature lurks when there's no light.
> It finds the children in their beds,
> It sings dark dreams into their heads.
> And when it hungers, in it steals
> To take the child and make a meal.

Hadley is frustrated that he cannot explain the rhyme to the party and will run away as soon as he can.

Other children, and even some of the adults, can explain the poem. It is from an old tale called "Oni the Child Thief." According to the tale, an evil monster disguises itself during the day, looking for children. Later, under cover of night, it assumes its hideous true form as it prowls house to house. The legend states that as the monster passes a house, the occupants (particularly the children) have nightmares. Any children the oni finds out of bed, it carries off to feast upon later. For a second poem (with clues) about the oni, consult the Monster Manual, p. 239.

The tale is an exaggerated telling of oni like Groth (see "The Messenger" later in this section).

Roleplaying Hadley

Hadley communicates by gesture and occasionally crudely written notes. He is eight years old, so his written vocabulary is small and error-prone. He won't write more than a sentence or two on the spot. But he might prepare a note over a longer period of time and bring it to the party, as he did with the poem.

Resist the temptation to say "Hadley is trying to tell you…" instead of letting the players work things out. Part of Hadley's character is the frustration of communicating without speaking.

When it comes to Hadley's overall role in the story, you have a few options: You can treat him as a static character who offers help at strategic intervals. Or you can develop him into a co-hero of the story, emphasizing first his outsider "Hardly" status with the others in the town, only to have him become the object of praise at the end. Finally, he might become a fan. If one of the party is particularly sympathetic to Hadley, it can be enjoyable to have the two form a bond, with Hadley announcing (perhaps through a drawn picture at the end) that he wants to grow up to be like that adventurer.

The Messenger

Delbert Dingleham (CN male human) lives in a forlorn cottage near the edge of town, abutting the hill. Known around town as an unmotivated scatterbrained lay-about, Delbert makes a meager living running deliveries and errands about the area. He is perennially late, rarely speaks in full sentences, and sometimes delivers packages to the wrong people (even though the villagers clearly label the parcels).

As the party later discovers, Delbert is not what he seems. The true Delbert Dingleham was "dispensed with" several weeks ago, and an oni (MM 239) named Groth (LE female oni) has disguised herself to take his place. Playing the part well, Groth has used Delbert's occupation to locate the area children. Contrary to the nursery rhyme Hadley shares, Groth's primary motivation is not eating children. Instead, she is kidnapping them.

Roleplaying Groth as Delbert

Intelligent and cunning, Groth is fighting against her nature to pretend to be Delbert. So she plays up the absentminded and unintelligent aspects of Delbert's personality. She flawlessly mimics his deep drawling voice. When a character asks a question, "Delbert" repeats the question back at a painfully slow cadence, and then gives an answer that is as non-informative as possible. While Groth studied Delbert for several days before taking his place, she does not have much information on his history, and may trip up if asked about things that took place more than a month ago.

The Oni's Companion

Groth does not dwell alone. In fact, she is working for a duergar (MM 122) named Almgrasp (LE male dwarf). Knowing the true nature of the mounds, Almgrasp is hunting for a very specific treasure: A book with the formula for creating a Brimstone Mace, a rare weapon thought lost over the

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centuries. Almgrasp believes he can forge a new Brimstone Mace and sell it to the highest bidder.

Almgrasp believes that the tomb contains other treasures. He has offered Groth a substantial share of the coin and jewels but has not told Groth of the book. Groth has been charged with acquiring labor to dig a passage to the tomb. Believing they are easier to control, Groth has been kidnapping children. Groth initially thought five would do. However, their lack of strength, proneness to injury, and inexperience has required Groth to acquire a few more.

Almgrasp and Groth believe they can finish the tunnel within the next few days. Almgrasp spends all of his time down in the tunnels, a relentless slave driver. Meanwhile Groth acts as Delbert, acquiring goods and food to keep the underground operation running smoothly.

The Sheered Goat, and Ending a Day of Investigation

Between walking and interviewing, the party should exhaust the day about the same time they run out of people to interview. Staying at one of the farms might be the best option. Rance will offer, but others will provide service for 2 sp. Otherwise, the party may occupy the two rooms at the modest local tavern, The Sheered Goat (1 gp/night).

In addition to providing a hot meal, the tavern provides you one additional setting for interviews. You may choose to fill in any missing details from the parents or other parts of the investigation through tavern conversation. Delbert, though, will not show up at the tavern.

Minstrelsy is a rare treat in Hillsend. A song or story may earn a character free food, or even free lodging for a night. A successful DC 10 Charisma (Performance) is a sure hit, while a DC 15 is a performance that will be talked about for months to come.

A Change of Heart

As the characters enjoy a good night's rest (at Rance', the tavern, or one of the other farms), an event occurs that spurs Rance into action: His own son vanishes.

As morning dawns, the party awakes to the sound of Rance's goons approaching. They oafishly convey an offer from Rance. "Find my son Steel, bring him back to me alive, and I will pay you handsomely." Rance will offer the party six giant boar or the cash equivalent (300 gp). Furthermore, if they bring back the kidnapper, dead or alive, he will give them a family heirloom: the *horseshoes of speed* (see appendix B). Rance knows the magical properties of the horseshoes and will brag about them.

The thugs explain that Steel was missing from his bed this morning and that the pane of his window was entirely removed and placed outside of the house. They entreat the party to come to the house. Rance's homestead is a quarter mile outside of town on the east side, immediately south of the Ulberts' land.

> The dew-laden prairie grass glistens in the morning light, surrounding the wealthy Spinner ranch with a twinkling aura that stands in contrast with the mood of the place. Before the front entry, Rance Spinner paces back and forth, one hand on his chin, the other on the rapier strapped to his belt. A couple of his henchman stand to the side, unsure how to assist their master.

Rance's mood is dark. He is angry, looking for someone to blame. But he is also experiencing grief. Having paid little attention to family, this sudden loss has prompted him to reassess his role as father. When speaking to the party, his moods shift mercurially. He blames Townmaster Chickpea for not having taken action earlier (in contradiction to Rance's earlier position). He randomly entreats the gods, particularly Gwaeron Windstrom, to find his son. And he laments that he has been a poor father, promising to change.

As he collects himself, Rance is suddenly keen on the theory that marauding orcs are capturing children to be sold into slavery, and even suggests that Terrence Ulbert may ultimately be behind the orcs. He offers a wild theory that Ulbert and the orcs are in league to snatch his land and destroy the Spinner legacy.

If the adventurers ask, Rance will take them to see Steel's room. With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Investigation) check, an adventurer can see a few dusty footprints just under the window, and they are adult-sized. If the check is greater than 15, the

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adventurer can also ascertain that the shoes were leather-soled, designed for silent movement.

If the party checks outside of the window, they will find the windowpane. A successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check will reveal that the window was removed from outside with the assistance of a fine blade, such as a knife or dagger. The attacker also left prints, and a DC 10 Survival check reveals a few drag marks moving off in the direction of the town (perpendicular to the Ulbert's farm) and footprints similar to the ones inside. About 30 feet from the house, Steel was lifted onto the shoulders of the kidnapper. A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) will reveal this to an adventurer. All of this should serve as a subtle clue (given what Chap says about the orcs in the next section) that the orcs are not the culprits.

Hadley is prowling around outside as well, staying out of site. Players must succeed in a DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) throw before they will be able to see him, though with a 15 or greater they are aware of a presence watching them. If caught, he will be unable to reveal anything, and will run away at first opportunity.

Once the oni's footprints lead into the grass, it becomes impossible to track. The oni is adept at hiding her trail.

Rance suggests that Chap the blacksmith may have actionable information about the most recent orc sightings. After all, she knows everyone. He asks the party to tell her the story and request that she spread the word to be on the lookout for Steel. He advises them to steer clear of the Ulberts.

If the players visit Chap the blacksmith, they will find some additional clues. If, on the other hand, they go to the Ulberts, Terrence will meet them outside the farm and tell them he has spotted orcs on his property.

The Clue at the Blacksmith's Stall

If the characters do visit Chap a second time, they find her engaged in conversation with Delbert. She is coaxing him into giving her some piece of information, but he is unable to hold his concentration long enough to answer to her satisfaction. She is annoyed.

As soon as she sees the adventurers, she sees a new opportunity to gather information. She engages them right away, asking about the ordeal at Rance's. She has heard rumors but is interested in acquiring knowledge. Delbert stays in the stall, apparently examining his fingernails. She asks whether the party has any idea what happened, if they have gathered any clues, and if they have theories about who may be to blame.

Chap won't answer any of the party's questions until she feels that they have given her sufficient information about Steel's disappearance and Rance's reaction. This is a bartering process for her. Once she is satisfied, she discloses that the only news she's heard about the orcs is that a group of travelers saw them east of town yesterday.

However, as soon as the subject of the orcs arises, Delbert interrupts.

> Suddenly attentive to the conversation, Delbert blurts, "When dropping off a parcel at the Ulbert house this morning, I saw the orcs walking along the eastern boundary of the fields. They were pulling along a covered wagon. I think I could hear people calling from inside the wagon. If you hurry, perhaps you can catch them near Ulbert's eastern field."

An adventurer with a passive Perception greater than 14 will be struck by the fact that this was a remarkably lucid statement from an individual who rarely speaks coherently on the topic at hand.

After giving this remarkable piece of information, Delbert lapses back into his normal non sequiturs. By disclosing this information, Groth (disguised as Delbert) believes she can send the adventurers on a wild goose chase. Since she and Groth have all of the children she believes they will need, her goal now is to pin the blame on the orcs while she and Almgrasp locate the treasure and escape.

If the party decides to follow up on Delbert's intelligence, proceed to "The Orc Poachers."

If the players seem unconvinced that the orcs did it, or if you want to expedite the encounter, you may wish to work in another clue: Delbert's shoes are leather-soled ranger's boots. This choice of attire is discordant with his line of work as a local messenger, who would more likely have low quality pauper's shoes. If confronted, Delbert will ramble

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incoherently, saying something about his brother, and that the shoes were a gift. Assuming the characters found the footprints at the Spinner farm, a DC 20 Wisdom (Survival) check, if successful, will confirm that Delbert's footprints match the footprints found at Rance's.

The Orc Poachers

The orcs have acquired a cart with thick wooden walls and a roof. They are going about their true business: Poaching and steeling livestock. And their current target is the flock of **giant goats** (MM 326) on the Ulberts' land. Their cart can typically only accommodate no more than a half dozen large animals at a time. But they load the animals up and bring them back to a cave in a prairie hill a few miles east of town.

If the adventurers hurry directly from the blacksmith, they can catch the orcs in the act. As they near the Ulberts' land, they catch site of the wagon at a distance. Six **orc** (MM 246) poachers are busy forcing goats into the wagon. The goats are bleating noisily, and from a distance may sound like children calling.

If the party takes too long getting to the site of the orcs, the poachers have left back to their camp. The fresh tracks from the cart are easy to follow, and the party can track the orcs to their camp, or perhaps catch them along the way.

As soon as the orcs see the adventurers, they stop what they are doing and draw their weapons. They will fight until half of the group is killed or subdued, at which point the remaining orcs will flee back to their camp.

What the Orcs Know

If an orc is captured, it may be persuaded or threatened to reveal any of the following:

- The location of the orc camp is a few miles away, and the orc will disclose its exact location if it feels threatened.
- They have been traveling for a many months, but for the last few weeks this bit of land kept their bellies full. A small part of the larger group has camped here while others scout the surrounding region looking for a more permanent home.
- There are seven **orcs** (MM 246) at the encampment, along with their **orog** leader Snar (MM 247).

The orcs know nothing about the missing children.

A successful DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) or DC 12 Charisma (Intimidation) will get the orcs talking.

The Orc Camp

The adventurers may pursue a lead and move on to the orc camp. The orcs there are engaged in whatever passes for domestic life in an orc horde. They have fashioned a pen for the captured livestock, and the pen has dozens of animals of assorted kind. A shallow cave provides sleeping quarters for the orcs, but they do their cooking before the cave's mouth at a large fire pit with a spit for roasting animals. A pile of animal bones near the cave are all that remain of many of the animals they have captured.

The orcs are on the lookout, unlikely to be surprised. They will attack as soon as they notice the party. If you wish to make Snar a more difficult adversary for high level characters, you can make him an **Orc War Chief** (MM 247). If Snar is a War Chief, he will command his orcs into positions that give them a tactical advantage.

The terrain is uneven. Orcs in the cave may easily find partial cover. Those near the pen may be able to seek cover behind animals. Likewise, the ground above the cave may provide an advantageous position for attacking orcs near the livestock but will make it impossible to attack those in the cave. The orcs may also try to prod the animals into charging at characters, though the orcs themselves have no mastery over the animals.

Orcs will fight until Snar is dead, and then will flee. These orcs have no relevant information to disclose to the party.

Should the players loot the shallow cave, they will find some of the treasures pillaged from local travelers: four silver mugs (15 sp each), a small pouch of five peridots (25 gp each) and a leather-bound book that is completely blank (20 gp). Snar carries a pouch containing 130 gp and a pearl (100 gp).

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Terrence Ulbert's Thanks

Terrence Ulbert will seek the party out to thank them for stopping the poachers. While this is a minor thing compared to his missing daughter, he is grateful, nonetheless. He offers them a tin of Restorative Ointment (see appendix B) — "common stock for a herdsman's pantry," he says — but regrets that he has no cash on hand with which to reward them.

When he hears that the orcs had nothing to do with the disappearance of the children, he shows regret and then suggests they had back to town to check in with Chap. But as the party leaves the farm, a child comes running toward them wildly banging a pot with a rock attempting to get their attention.

Hadley Ulbert has something he wants to show them.

Hadley's Discovery

If they players follow Hadley's lead, he takes them to a new location: The foot of the large hill (the site of the buried fortress-mine) several hundred feet away from Delbert's shack. As he gets close to the shack, he points to it and then repeatedly gestures toward his own feet. Hadley is trying to convey to them that Delbert's shoes are the ones that left the footprints. However, he dares not go closer to the house, and will give up trying to convey the clue if the adventurers do not understand. After all, he has something better to show them.

As he nears the foot of the hill, he points to a caved-in patch of ground. The children digging the tunnel to Torbrand's fortress-mine have (intentionally or unintentionally) caused a small cave-in. The hole is only a foot or so in diameter. It is 20 feet above the tunnel floor. But the party may be able to see in with dark vision or sources of light. Hadley gestures to his ears. He can hear something. With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, an adventurer can hear the faint sound of a child crying.

The Tomb of Sherstave Torbrand

In this final part of the adventure, the party must work its way through the tunnel an into the fortress-mine. There they will find Almgrasp and the children.

At this point, there are a few options: They party may try to use the hole as an entrance, or they may look for the intended opening. Hadley will follow at a safe distance. If fighting breaks out, he will use each turn to move 30 feet from danger, and then hide or dodge.

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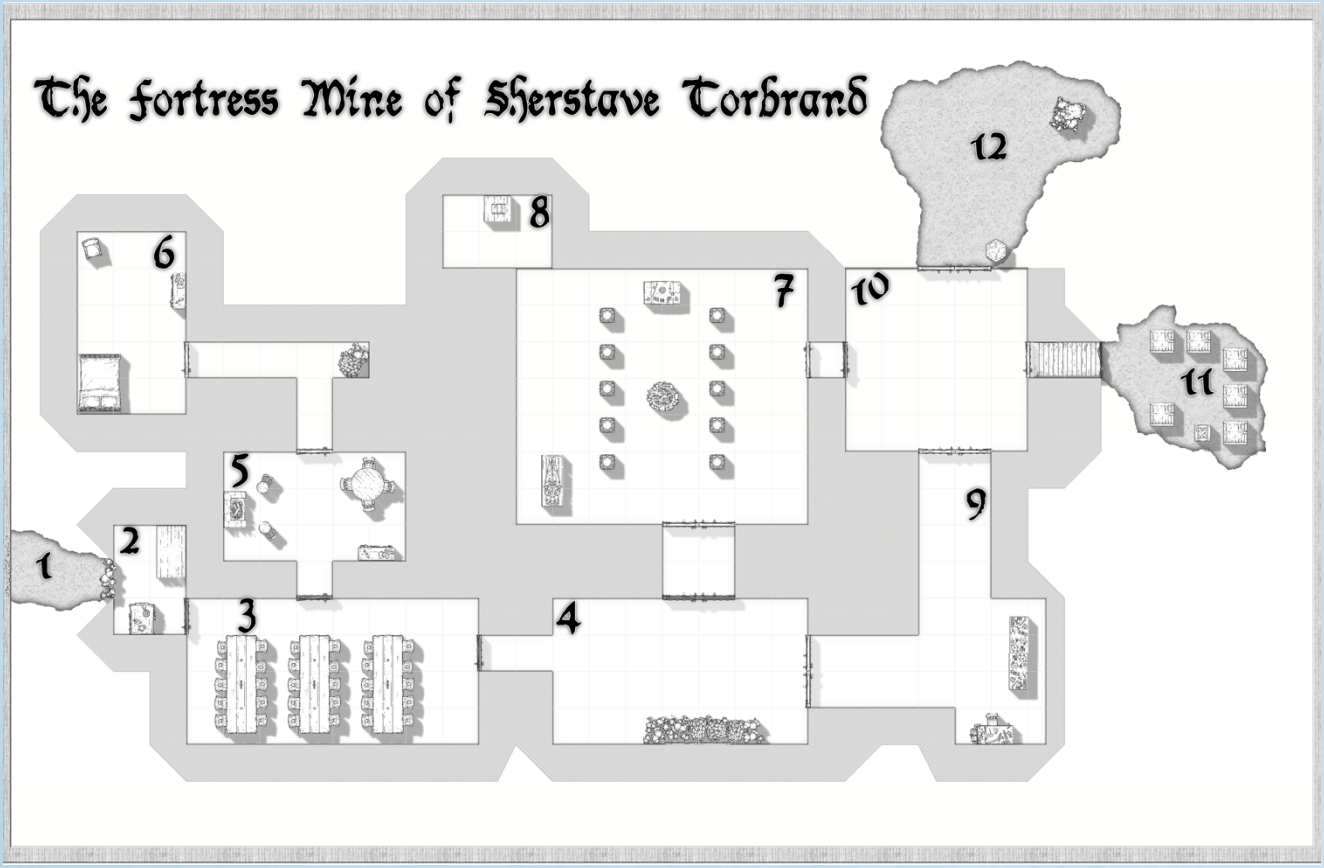


Figure 1 Map of Torbrand Fortress-Mine

T1. The Tunnel

The tunnel is the only available entrance to the tomb. Created by Almgrasp and the children, it is narrow (5 ft), rough-edged, unstable, and only five feet tall. The tunnel itself follows a meandering path, as Almgrasp had the children dig through softer dirt when possible. Because of twists and turns, line of sight is limited to 15 feet. Since the walls are dirt (rather than stone), there is no echo. The tunnels are dark, as is the entirety of the fortress-mine.

Option 1: Entering the Tunnel through Delbert's Shack

If the party attempts to ascertain the entrance to the mine, they may notice from the tunnel that it points generally toward Delbert's shack.

The primary entrance is in Delbert's shack beneath a trap door in the far left-hand corner of the one-room shack. Groth (disguised as Delbert) is in the cottage. She is unaware that the party knows anything about the tunnel. Playing her part, she will gladly accept the task of running an errand and will also chatter amicably in Delbert's fractured and rambling manner.

If asked directly about the tunnel, she will deny knowledge of it. But she will begin to slip out of character. If reasoned with, she may decide to flee. However, if adventurers become threatening, she will change into her **oni** (MM 239) form and fight, preventing the party from entering the tunnel.

An oni is likely beyond the capabilities of a party at or below 4th level. Removing her *regeneration* ability will reduce the challenge of fighting her. However, you may need to provide the party with opportunity to escape. If Groth is reduced to half health or believes Almgrasp to be dead or captured, she may decide to flee. (You may choose to award half XP for this.)

Option 2: Entering via the Hole Hadley Found

Heroes may attempt to enlarge the hole or use magic to enter through the cave-in site. If they are successful, they will drop into an unguarded segment of the long hall. Proceeding west into the

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tunnel will take the players to Delbert's cottage, which they will be able to make out through cracks in the trap door. If they are too loud, Groth will hear them, transform into her oni form, and fight as described above.

Proceeding east in the tunnel will lead toward the tomb. The badly decayed carcass of the real Delbert is in this section of tunnel. Almgrasp and Groth use the decaying body to keep the children frightened. Delbert was slain by Groth at his home in the middle of the night and knew nothing of Almgrasp or his plot.

Almgrasp and the children found the entrance to the tomb just hours before. But in the process of breaking through the strong dwarven stone wall, one of the children was hurt. Almgrasp has left the badly injured Lilla Fensley to perish on her own. She is at the end of the tunnel where the children finally managed to break into the tomb.

A pile of fallen rubble, including dwarf-hewn stone blocks, have pinned Lilla's entire left leg. Her leg is crushed, and she is badly battered from the debris. She is at 1 hp, and because of her crushed leg her walking speed is halved even if freed. She is light and can be carried by any medium or greater creature with Strength 10 or greater. When carrying her, an adventurer must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution check once per ten minutes. On failure, that character must put her down for ten minutes (though another party member may take her).

If an adventurer is carrying her during combat, all non-spell attack rolls are at disadvantage. The hero may put her down with a bonus action but lifting her takes an action. Lilla will spend her turn crawling as far from combat as she can, hiding if possible.

While in distress under the rocks, Lilla cannot communicate anything but pain and a desire to be freed. But upon being freed and cared for, she will tell the party what she knows.

What Lilla Knows

- She was kidnapped from her house by Delbert, whom she informs the party is actually the female oni Groth.
- The real Delbert is dead, and his body is in the tunnel. He was dead before the first child was kidnapped.
- Groth is working with an evil dwarf named Almgrasp, who seems to be in charge. Almgrasp is exceedingly cruel, and all of the children fear him.
- The children have been forced into digging the tunnel to the tomb of a dwarf named Sherstave Torbrand. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check—with advantage for dwarves—will reveal Torbrand's history as a greedy failed king who led many of his people to slaughter (see "Background" in the adventure summary).
- Groth initially kidnapped five children, thinking they would be enough. But when Almgrasp was unhappy with the slow progress, Groth took Bristle and Gert.
- Bristle was strong-willed and tried to escape. Almgrasp punished him severely, injuring him badly enough that he cannot work. Almgrasp seems to have a reason for keeping him alive, though, and when they broke through to the tomb, he dragged the bound Bristle along with him (and the other children)
- Almgrasp did not know how close the fortress-mine was. He brought in Steel Spinner (Rance's son) today thinking there was another day's digging. Almsgrasp was jubilant to discover a way into the mine earlier than he expected.

If asked about details of the children's health or wellbeing, Lilla will assure the party that everyone is alive. But she is concerned that they will not be for long. She suspects that Almgrasp has another reason for wanting the children. After all, he took all of the other children into the tomb.

T2. The Kitchen

Almgrasp had no prior knowledge of the layout of the underground palace-turned-tomb. The room that he happened to tunnel into is the kitchen and pantry. Floors in the pantry are paved with cut stone with grooves to prevent spilt liquid from making the floors slick.

Across the room from the tunnel, old iron pots and kettles line the workspace. The cooking area along the south wall is covered with rubble from the chimney that collapsed hundreds of years ago. Here and there, moldered wooden barrels and crates,

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once stacked neatly, have collapsed on their own weight. Even after a century of disuse, a faint smell of smoke still lingers. The wooden door on the far side of the room is slightly ajar.

Other than the iron pots and a few kitchen utensils, the contents of the room have long ago ceased to be usable. The contents of the crates and barrels have already rotted away, and only powdery remains are left. While the chimney long ago collapsed, a small opening remains. Vermin and other small animals have entered the tomb through it.

The workspace in the room provides a few small niches in which one could hide. Lilla and Hadley announce that they would prefer to hide here and await the adventurers.

The door on the western side of the room is slightly ajar. The door can be opened silently.

If the party did not enter the tunnel through Delbert's shack, Groth has not yet discovered the party. For higher level parties (four or more at 5th level or greater), Groth will patrol the long tunnel at regular intervals, walking from the shack down to the kitchen. If she senses anything wrong, she may explore further. (For lower-level parties, she will stay in the shack.)

T3. The Great Hall

When Sherstave Torbrand created this underground lair, he intended it to simultaneously serve three purposes: a palace, a fortress, and a mine. This hall was designed for royal celebrations, hosting parties of dwarves.

The great hall opens before you. While the ceiling is low for a room of this size, the adornments once made it feel bright and open. Originally ornamented with colorful murals of dwarf miners carting rich loads of jewels, gold, and platinum from a mine, the wall provides a clear picture of what Torbrand envisioned happening here. But with age, the paint of the murals has flaked. Like the mine itself, the mural is but a faded dream.

The ceiling is eight feet high, the walls here and throughout the mine are smoothed stone. In the palace portion of the mine, the floors are paved with polished grey stone tiles. In lamp light they give off a silver glimmer. While the floors are dusty, numerous smudges, tracks, and marks indicate that the tomb is not empty.

Large tables with long benches fill the room. Made of thick planks and iron fixtures, these tables stand strong, showing no sign of their age. Near the kitchen door is a cache of digging tools: pickaxes, shovels, buckets, and lantern oil. Almgrasp made the children leave the tools here. Among these tools are two *potions of healing* that Almgrasp has stowed in case of an emergency.

A small door on the northern end leads to the king's residence. It is locked, but the door is weak. The lock can be picked, or the door can be broken with weapons or the pickax (AC 11, HP 10).

The floor on the south-eastern corner is coated with a black and glistening goo. This is a **grey ooze** (MM 243) that will attack any player who comes within five feet. It may also be spurred to action by a loud noise, such as knocking over a shovel or destroying a door. The ooze's preferred method of attack is to wait until the party has spread out, and then attack the last party member. It will follow the party into adjacent rooms.

An ornate door stands ajar in the middle of the eastern wall. Carved to convey the same grandiose vision as the mural on the wall, this door is a work of art. This is the door through which Almgrasp took the children a short while ago. Within this room, a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check will alert the adventurers to the faint sound of high-pitched squeals caused by the swarming stirges in the entrance hall (T4). If the check is 15 or higher, the adventurer may also hear the muffled struggling of a child.

T4. The Entrance

The door from the great hall leads into the original entrance.

Carved directly into the bedrock, the walls of the entrance hall are carved into sculpture depicting joyous miners at work. With a gold-leafed domed ceiling, every sound made in this room reverberates thunderously. As with the great hall, this is a room designed to impress. But in the center of this regal hall is a lie of animal waste standing two feet tall.

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On the northern wall, the bas-relief depicts an ancient temple's archway. And in the middle of the archway is a pair of gilded iron doors. These lead to the Temple of Dumathoin, which is now the sepulcher of Torbrand.

On the eastern edge is a hallway ten feet wide, sturdy double doors standing wide open. That hallway leads toward the mine and was constructed to be large enough to allow wagons loaded with ore or rubble to pass in and out.

The once-impressive main gates along the southern wall have been reduced to rubble. The dwarves, fleeing an orc horde, collapsed the main entrance before abandoning the mine. Near the collapsed entrance is an inscription hastily chiseled by the departing dwarves.

> Here stands the hall of King Sherstave Torbrand, the first and only king of Torbrand Fortress-Mine. The king slain, the mine unproductive, we the remainder have chosen to seal this cursed place and depart. Torbrand Fortress-Mine has been the death-site for our kinsfolk, including the king himself. May it now be a tomb left in everlasting silence.

In the north-eastern corner is a cluster of 8 **stirges** (MM 284). They are competing with each other to get to a small heap on the ground. This heap is Peel Kant. He attempted to flee from Almgrasp to find and tend to Lilla. Almgrasp delivered a blood-drawing blow that attracted the blood-thirsty stirges.

Peel has already sustained damage from the stirges. He will last less than a minute (6 rounds of combat) before he is reduced to 0 hit points from blood loss.

T5. Torbrand's Residence

North of the great hall is the king's residence.

> Filled with rich furnishings decayed with age, one can readily imagine the splendorous life of this failed dwarf king. The once comfortable sitting room was the center of the Torbrand family life.

The room is furnished with chairs, a table, and a low shelf of long-decayed knick-knacks. A few skeletons of rats and other vermin litter the room.

The center of the northern wall opens into a T-shaped hallway. The eastern half of the hallways has collapsed. The western edge leads into the bed chamber.

A second **grey ooze** (MM 243) lurks beneath the table in the northwestern corner of the room. If the gray ooze from T3 has followed the players into this room, this grey ooze will instinctually move to block the door to T5 while the other ooze blocks the door back to T3. Otherwise, if any character passes within 5 feet of the ooze, it will follow that person and attack when it has the element of surprise.

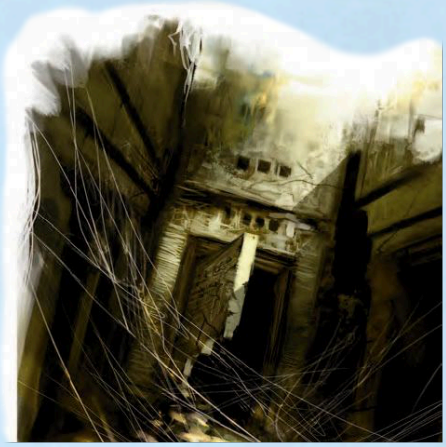
T6. The Royal Bedchamber

> Time has been unkind to this once royal bedchamber. The lavish furniture is splintered. The bed has been shredded. And the room is filled with a nauseating stench. You recoil in horror as you notice the pile of bones, filth, and decaying animal remains heaped on what was once the bed.

As the players enter the room a **grick** (MM 173) drops from the stone ceiling and attacks. It has made this room its lair, devouring anything that makes its way into the cave. With only small animals like rats and stirges as prey, the grick is ravenous. Its primary intention is to kill and eat at least one in the party.

The decaying refuse in the room is noxious. Prior to each round of combat, any player in the room must make a Constitution saving throw (DC 12) or become poisoned for five minutes.

Undisturbed for hundreds of years, a treasure chest sits in the southwest corner. It contains forty adamantine ingots (10 gp each, and each weighing 1 pound), which represented the last of the fungible wealth that Sherstave Torbrand had brought with him to construct this new home.



T7. The Temple

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of Dumathoin

The temple of Dumathoin is the center of the complex, a symbolic reference to the deity's centrality in the health and wealth of a mine. The duergar Almgrasp is currently exploring this room, looking for the book.

The enormous temple with white tiled floors, vaulted ceilings, and ornately carved pillars provided a place of reverence for the dwarves that once worked in the fortress-mine. In the center of the room is a brazier standing five feet across. Even after many hundreds of years, blue supernatural flames lick the iron dome covering the brazier. Beyond it stands an alter with the dusty paraphernalia of religious practice. A stylized mountain has been etched into the stone wall behind the alter, with a glimmering blue gem mounted at its center.

The vaulted roof is 20 feet high on the outside of the pillars and 35 feet high in the middle of the room. The tiled floor is smooth.

The perpetual flame at the center of the room is hot enough that the iron near the edge of the brazier glows faintly orange. The brazier has been heated so long that it is malleable and will collapse if any force is applied to it. However, the flame will continue. The light from the flame is dim and reaches 10 feet in all directions.

Atop the alter are the implements of worship, including a golden tankard encrusted with sapphires (200 gp) and a ceremonial mithril platter (18 gp).

With a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) or Intelligence (History) check, an adventurer will recognize the etched mountain with a sapphire as the symbol of Dumathoin, the god of buried secrets in the dwarven pantheon. The sapphire (200 gp) can be pried loose with a successful DC 15 Strength check. However, if a character attempts to loosen it by striking it, it will fracture and crumble to the floor. The shattered jewel may be gathered as sapphire dust (150 gp).

In the southwestern corner of the temple is a sarcophagus, the final resting place of King Sherstave Torbrand. Engraved in the sarcophagus in dwarvish is a partial epitaph, the right half having crumbled away:

Under Dumathoin's eternal eye rests the First King of Tor…
Founder of the illustrious mine, dwelt and ruled here nigh a….
With mighty Orctremor felled many an adver…
May he now know in death all that he sought…

The sarcophagus can be opened with a successful DC 20 Strength check (or a cooperative effort totaling 20). The king has been entombed with Orctremor, a +1 magical Battleaxe (see appendix B). The dwarf's fine clothes have deteriorated over time, and the heavy weapon has crushed the fragile ribcage of the skeletal remains.

The dwarf child Bristle is firmly bound, pushed up against the sarcophagus. There are hints that the duergar may be planning some sort of necromantic rite with the boy.

Almgrasp is a **duergar** (MM 122) with 32 hit points. He is attempting to force open a door in the northwestern wall, believing it to be the entrance to a vault. He is noisily using his ax to chop at the door. If the players enter stealthily, he will not hear them. The pillars of the room further obscure the view between his location and the entrance. However, if players are using lights, he will notice (he has dark vision, and is not carrying a lantern).

The remaining children's legs are strung together by a length of rope (AC 5, HP 5), and are huddled in the northeastern corner near Almgrasp. Their ankles are tied to form a chain so they may all walk in unison only at a slow pace (10 feet/round). The children are frightened, and only Garett the half-elf can see in the darkness. If Garett or any other children see the adventurers, the children will begin chattering among themselves, which may draw Almgrasp's attention.

Upon becoming aware of the adventurers, Almgrasp will become hostile. Recognizing that he is outnumbered, he may shield himself behind the children. If he becomes aware of the party before they see him, he will cast *enlarge* or *invisibility* before engaging. He may attempt any number of ploys to force the adventurers to rescue the children rather than attack him.

The damaged door that Almgrasp tried to break down can be picked with thieves' tools (on a successful DC 10 Dexterity check) or smashed (AC

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11, HP 7). However, it does not lead to a vault. It leads, via a short sloping hallway, to room T10.

The room Almgrasp seeks is hidden behind a secret door in the northwestern corner. The stone door blends in with the grey rock wall, but a small adamantine handle can be seen with a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check. It leads to room T8.

T8. The Vestry

King Torbrand used the temple as a cover for his more nefarious interests. The vestry, secret and closed off to all but the priest with whom he colluded, contains the artifacts of his research into infernal weapons.

> Originally designed as a place of solitude for the temple priest, the vestry is a simple room hidden behind the temple. But the room is cluttered with small statues. Diagrams and sketches are pasted to the walls. In the center of the room stands a marble stone table with a book.

This room was used for researching the Brimstone Mace. One diagram on the wall depicts various mine shafts descending beneath the earth with annotations in Dwarvish. The annotations suggest various possible locations for a portal to Gahenna, many with follow-up annotations indicating that the portal was not found. Another illustration depicts a dwarf extracting brimstone from a sulfurous pit. Another appears to be an alchemical diagram depicting how to magically maintain a sphere of brimstone. The diagrams are firmly pasted. Any attempt to remove them results in their tearing and crumbling.

Around the walls of the room are statues of various creatures (yugoloths, MM 311-314) from Gehenna. While they might be casually mistaken for idols, Torbrand had them for a different purpose: He was researching the monsters he believed he may encounter while trying to acquire the brimstone for the mace. The statues are fashioned from clay, and none of them have any value, nor are any of them enchanted.

A small table in the room has been used as a writing desk. Upon it sits a single book, a quill, and an ink pot whose contents have long since turned to dust. The slim volume has no markings on the outside. It is entirely devoted to the formula for constructing a Brimstone Mace, a powerful magic item long thought lost (see appendix B). It contains elaborate and detailed instructions on creating the mace and then enchanting it. The mace that can be crafted is *very rare* and requires 15 pounds of brimstone before it can be constructed (see the rules for crafting in DMG 128-129). The journal mentions that the blue flame in the temple is to be used in the enchantment of the brimstone. Furthermore, it notes that the book itself has been enchanted to resists destruction. It will not decay and cannot be destroyed by non-magical means. However, a note in the book states that as a precaution, the book is also vulnerable to the blue flames in the brazier. Torbrand seemed to have intended to burn the book if things went awry. However, his death in battle left that plan unfulfilled.

If you would prefer to not present the option for the players to have a crafting design, you may make the book incomplete, insufficiently detailed, or enchanted and unreadable.

T9. The Supply Room

The eastern exit from the original entrance (T4) leads down a broad hallway into an open space used to store mining equipment.

> Tools line the two walls of this open storage area. In its center stand a pair of mining carts. Even after a century, every tool in this room looks sturdy and usable, a testament to the craft of the dwarves who fashioned them. A long-cold furnace dominates the eastern wall. It is not hard to imagine dozens of dwarves participating in the complex process of moving and refining oar in this room.

Against the eastern wall is the great furnace used for smelting and purifying precious metals, while the walls are lined with the tools of metalworkers as well as miners. Among the tools, three ornate adamantine pickaxes (60 gp each) stand out.

The wide hall extends north toward a pair of sturdy and utilitarian doors. Above the doors, etched into the stone, is the following dwarven inscription:

> Stone is the soul of earth, yielding her bounty to those whose labor is done in love.

This is the entrance to the mine.

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T10. The Mine Entrance

The entry way to the mine is a utilitarian affair. On the north side, the two great doors to the mine itself are barred closed. A wooden door with the mark of Dumathoin is recessed into the wall on the west side. On the east side is a re-enforced iron door with a sophisticated lock of gnomish design. This leads to the strong room, or vault, where a mine's treasure is typically kept before it is smelted into ingots and transported.

> Before you stand towering iron doors, a heavy bar securing it. Large dwarven runes are etched into the door. Two deep parallel grooves run from the barred doors to the entrance, tracks to direct the mine carts. An entrance designed for a city of miners stands silent.

The wooden door leads down a flight of stairs into the temple (T7).

The mark of Dumathoin, carved into the wall, is a carved mountain with a small sapphire (25 gp) embedded at the mountain's base. Adventurers with the appropriate tools (artisan's tools, thrive's tools, or a hammer) can retrieve the sapphire with a successful DC 15 Dexterity check.

The re-enforced iron door is locked, and an adventurer with thieves' tools must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity check. This check may be repeated but cost ten minutes of time each failed attempt.

Finally, the main door to the mine is barred shut. The beam across the door is exceedingly heavy. A collective strength check of 30 must be reached to heave it from the door. Each adventurer willing to attempt to move the door may roll a Strength check, and if the total of all contributing members reaches or exceeds 30, the bar can be moved. If it is not moved at least 5 feet from the door, the doors cannot be opened, and the feat must be repeated. Once the bar is removed, the door can be opened normally.

As soon as the party opens the doors to the mine, 8 **specters** (MM 279) burst into the room, hungry to devour the adventurers. (To adjust balance for level 4 players, you can reduce the number of specters to 4. Adjust text in "T11. The Failed Mine" as well.)

The specters will not proceed into a room marked with Dumathoin's symbol. They will not enter the temple. Otherwise, they will follow the adventurers. The specters are not aligned with Almgrasp and Groth, and are just as likely to attack them.

T11. The Failed Mine

Now devoid of its undead inhabitants, this room is empty.

> The roughly hewn walls of the mine stand exactly as they must have been ten centuries ago. Across the vault, a pile of collapsed rubble stands where the main shaft must have opened, deeply grooved mine cart tracks still proceeding out from the pile of rock. Scorch marks climb the walls near the collapse. To the right of the mine's entrance is a stone pedestal upon which sits a clasped volume.

Unlike the floors elsewhere in the palace, the ground here is uneven. Other than the area around the cart tracks, the floor is considered difficult terrain. Cart tracks are not steel rails, but deep grooves that acted as guides for the cart wheels. A pile of rubble on the eastern side provides 3/4 cover.

The hefty tome is bound in cured hide, with pages made of enchanted velum. Even after hundreds of years, the book appears new. It has an adamantine strap around the middle, with a hasp designed to accommodate a large lock. However, the book is not locked.

The front page of the book says this:

> The Great Tome of the Mine of King Sherstave Torbrand, first ruler of the Fortress-Mine Torbrand. These enchanted pages record for all posterity the riches with which King Sherstave Torbrand has endowed this city. May the Fortress-Mine Torbrand stand mighty for centuries!

Underneath this inscription is the royal seal of Torbrand. The next few pages are detailed records of the operation of the mine: How many days it operated, and for each day how much oar was mined and what precious materials were yielded. A successful DC 10 Intelligence check will confirm that the mine yielded very little, an obvious failure.

On the third page is another inscription, this one in a different hand.

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King Sherstave Torbrand, founder of this useless and barren rubble heap, has sentenced us, the eight heads of the mine, to be sealed in this room. The sentence for treason is death. Yet when he threw us in here, he traced a sigil that I fear may cause us pain beyond our expected demise.

Treason is a serious charge, but one well warranted. When the mine was found lacking, not a vein encountered, we began to advise the king against this fruitless endeavor. Yet still he insisted. While we labored, Sherstave spent vast sums on the services of a red-robed mage who built a brazier and lit a magical flame. At this point we began to believe Sherstave was seeking not gold, but something else. And hence we conducted two treasonous acts. First, we located the volume he kept hidden in a secret room in the temple. We confirmed its malevolent content. A book of Gehenna. Sherstave has found the formula for constructing a powerful and evil weapon called the Brimstone Mace. As much a device of control as of war, we saw the danger in letting a tyrant wield it. And so we began our second treasonous endeavor: We attempted to cast the book into the blue flames of the brazier. We were caught, and here stand sentenced, the administrators of the mine consigned to die in the location of their failure.

This is the "justice" of a tyrant. Sherstave has been corrupted by his book. In seeking to control darkness, he has let darkness take him. But lo, the beat of orc drums.

As scribe and witness of the eight, I hereby sign,

Bullpike Cleftear

If an adventurer investigates the scorch marks near the shaft, a successful DC Intelligence (History) check will reveal that the mine was intentionally blasted with a spell or potion.

The eight skeletal remains of the eight heads of the mine (whose souls had become specters). Among their remains are an ancient platinum belt buckle of dwarven design (300 gp), an adamantine tinker's hammer (150 gp), and a pouch containing four small rubies (30 gp each).

T12. The Vault

Steep stairs lead down into the safe room. Large stone bins line the uneven cavern walls, receptacles for precious materials. All of them are empty.

The natural cavern served as a vault for the mine's anticipated treasures. Great empty bins stand testament to the riches the dwarves of Torbrand expected to find. In absence of treasure, this room was used to store the spare gear of the mine's guards.

A switch is hidden near the door at the top of the staircase. An adventurer with passive Perception at 14 or greater may notice the switch. Likewise, adventurers intentionally looking for traps may locate it with a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check.

The switch disarms a trap designed as a last level of defense for the vault. If not disabled, the trap will spring when a character steps onto the last step of the stairs. Crossbow bolts fire from both sides of the stairs, dealing 2d8 damage. A successful DC 15 Dexterity saving throw will halve the damage.

The mine never produced treasure, and so the vault is devoid of the expected loot. However, the guards left their spare armor in the vault, and among the low-grade leather armor is an *immovable rod* (see appendix B).

Concluding the Adventure

If the party brings Steel back to his family, Rance will pay his promised reward (see "A Change of Heart"), along with a bonus if Almgrasp is returned as well (dead or alive). The remaining villagers have contributed from the only treasure they have on hand: They offer the party two giant goats, a boar, and a lovely set of hand-forged horseshoes (15 sp). If the players decline the gifts, they must succeed on a DC 15 Charisma (Performance) check to convince the townspeople. Otherwise, the townspeople insist on their accepting the gifts.

Hadley ("Hardly") Ulbert has gone from pariah to hero among the children. To show his thanks, he delivers a hand-drawn picture of himself standing with the adventurers… on a sheet of the parchment

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from the mine's record book. It's a shame he can't explain how he got it.

If the party did not intercept the orcs, the raiding continues. You may optionally have Townmaster Chickpea request assistance before the adventurers leave.

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Appendix A: Monsters

The following monsters appear in this adventure. All references are to the Monster Manual (MM), 5th edition.

Monster	Source	Challenge Rating
Boar	MM 319	CR 1/4
Duergar	MM 132	CR 1
Giant Goat	MM 326	CR 1/2
Grey Ooze	MM 243	CR 1/2
Grick	MM 173	CR 2
Oni	MM 239	CR 7
Orc	MM 246	CR 1/2
Orog	MM 247	CR 2
Specter	MM 279	CR 1
Stirge	MM 284	CR 1/8

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Appendix B: Magical Items

This section describes the magical items available in this adventure. All references are to the Dungeon Master's Guide (DMG), 5th edition.

The Formula for the Brimstone Mace

Formula, very rare

This slim volume contains detailed instructions for the creation of the Brimstone Mace, a very rare magical item (requiring attunement) that can be crafted using the rules in DMG 128-129. Along with the 50,000 gp cost (spread over time) for crafting the item, 15 pounds of brimstone from a volcano in Gehenna is required.

When constructed, the Brimstone Mace is a +3 magical mace that requires attunement. Designed to be wielded by a ruler, the mace is a tool for controlling others. It has 10 charges and can be used to cast the following spells, even by non-magic users: *Crown of madness* (2nd level, consumes 1 charge), *Fireball* (3rd level, consumes 2 charges), *Mass suggestion* (6th or 7th level, consumes 5 charges). However, the mace is ineffective against infernals. Any attack role against an infernal is done at disadvantage. Attempting to cast one of the weapon's spells against an infernal results in the mace's disintegration. The mace regains 1d8 + 2 charges at dawn.

Horseshoes of Speed

Wondrous item, rare

These iron horseshoes come in a set of four. While all four shoes are affixed to the hooves of a horse or similar creature, they increase the creature's walking speed by 30 feet.

Source: DMG 175

Immovable Rod

Rod, uncommon

This flat iron rod has a button on one end. You can use an action to press the button, which causes the rod to become magically fixed in place. Until you or another creature uses an action to push the button again, the rod doesn't move, even if it is defying gravity.

The rod can hold up to 8,000 pounds of weight. More weight than that causes the rod to deactivate and fall. A creature can use an action to make a DC 30 Strength check, moving the fixed rod up to 10 feet on a success.

Source: DMG 175

Orctremor Battleax

Battleax, rare

This battleax was once wielded by the dwarf king Sherstave Torbrand. Ornately decorated, it bears the dwarven inscription "By Dumathoin's blue flame, enemies shall perish." It gives +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls. Enchanted by the Red Mage of Torbrand Fortress-Mine, the bonus is raised to +3 when used to attack orcs or half-orcs. On a critical hit, blue flames of the temple of Dumathoin ripple along the blade's edge, and it deals an additional 1d6 + 1 fire damage.

Restorative Ointment

Wonderous item, uncommon

This glass jar, 3 inches in diameter, contains 1d4 + 1 doses of a thick mixture that smells faintly of aloe. The jar and its contents weigh 1/2 pound.

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As an action, one dose of the ointment can be swallowed or applied to the skin. The creature that receives it gains 2d8 + 2 hit points, ceases to be poisoned, and is cured of any disease.

See “Keoghtom’s Ointment”, DMG 179

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